Information Sheet for Parents / Carers

Investigating Children's Agency when learning with AI

We are a team of researchers at University College London (UCL), working with colleagues at the University of Oxford. We are investigating how young people can stay in charge of their own learning when using AI-based tools.

We are inviting your child and you to take part in our research project, and we very much hope that you will allow them to take part. This information sheet answers questions you might have about the project. Please don't hesitate to contact **Prof. Manolis Mavrikis** if there is anything else you would like to know. Please also explain the research to your child and discuss whether or not they would like to take part.

Who is carrying out the research?

Principal Investigator: Professor Manolis Mavrikis, UCL Knowledge Lab, m.mavrikis@ucl.ac.uk

UCL Co-Investigators: Dr. Zaki Pauzi; Dr. Vidminas Vizgirda; Ms Yildiz Uzun; Ms Rahki Nair; Dr Kyrill Potapov

Collaborators (University of Oxford): Dr. Jun Zhao (University of Oxford); Dr. Leslye Dias Duran (University of Oxford); Dr. Isobel Voysey (University of Oxford)

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This project has been reviewed and approved by the UCL IOE Research Ethics Committee (ref. Z6364106/2026/09/12) and UCL Data Protection Office (ref. Z6364106/2026/10/135 social research).

Why is this research being conducted?

The aim of the project is to understand how young people can stay in charge of their own learning when using generative AI. We are studying how an application designed to support personal agency influences the way students make choices, set goals, and act deliberately during self-guided learning. We hope the findings will help design better tools and teaching approaches that support young people's agency in the age of AI. We are also interested in parents'/guardians' perspectives on how they observe young people' use of the application and their agency while using the application.

Why is my child invited to take part?

Your child is invited because they are secondary school student, either at a school taking part in the study or because you responded to one of our calls for participants.

Why am I invited to take part?

You are invited because you know your child's learning and study habits well, and can offer insights into how they use the application outside school and how they approach their learning more generally.

What does my child's participation involve?

The study runs over approximately five weeks and the full set of activities are as follows:

- Complete a short participant (demographic) questionnaire.
- Complete a short baseline questionnaire about how they make choices and feel about their learning at the start and again at the end .
- Take part in an introductory session explaining the study and the application they will be using.
- Have the opportunity to use a learning application as part of self-guided learning over approximately five weeks.
- Take part in a debrief of the research

Students in the interview group will additionally:

- Take part in a short interview each week (around 15–20 minutes) about how they are using the application and the choices they are making (and an informal check in to confirm they are comfortable continuing)
- Take part in a closing interview of approximately 20–30 minutes at the end of the study.

With your consent and your child's assent interviews will be audio-recorded and transcribed so that we can analyse them accurately. Recordings will be deleted once the transcript has been checked.

What does my participation involve?

We would like to invite you to take part in an informal interview of around sixty minutes, at the end of the study. This will be open conversations about your experience of the study and your observations of your child' use of the application, rather than a fixed set of questions. Interviews will take place in person or on Microsoft Teams at a time convenient for you. With your consent, the interview will be audio-recorded and transcribed.

Will anyone know my child and I have been involved?

No, not unless the participant chooses to tell others. All data collected are referred to using a pseudonymous study ID. No identifying personal information appears in research outputs (reports, publications, presentations), and any quotes used are anonymised.

Could there be any problems from taking part?

We do not anticipate any risks beyond those of typical classroom and computer-based learning activities. Some students may find reflecting on their own decision-making unfamiliar; participation is framed as non-assessed, and students may skip any question and stop at any time.

What data will be collected and how will it be protected?

Through the study we will collect the following:

- Consent/assent records (parental consent; student assent).
- Participant details needed to run the study: name, class, school, and a study ID.
- Basic demographics: age, gender (optional) and school year.
- Questionnaire responses
- Application interaction logs: date and time of use, session duration, features accessed, frequency of use, choices made within the app, and brief self-reported reasons for use.
- Anything your child types into the application, including goals they set, reflections they write, and questions or prompts they enter, together with the responses the application gives back.
- Audio recordings of both parent/carer and children interviews, and the transcripts made from them.

Interaction and questionnaire data are stored on secure UCL systems (UCL OneDrive for Business and UCL-managed servers). Even if a conversation or file is deleted from the chat screen, copies continue to stay in the interaction logs. Interview recordings are stored on UCL OneDrive for Business and transcribed using UCL Microsoft 365 services; once researchers have checked the transcripts for accuracy, the recordings are deleted.

Named Oxford researchers work with us on this study under a Data Sharing Agreement, with UCL as the lead data controller. Some of them will carry out interviews alongside UCL researchers, so they will know the participants they meet. For analysis, they can access interview transcripts, pseudonymised questionnaire responses, field notes and logs in which names have been replaced with a study code.

We use services from Microsoft (UCL OneDrive and Teams), Amazon Web Services (which runs the application and its AI models) and Qualtrics (questionnaires). These companies store or process information on UCL's behalf, under UCL's contracts with them. Also, Amazon's AI service automatically checks any image uploaded to the application. If an image is flagged, it is blocked, and Amazon may review it and report it to the NCMEC or another authority. This is separate from the study's own safeguarding procedures.
Apart from these, we will not share personal information with anyone else.
Anonymised data, consent and withdrawal records will be kept for a minimum of ten years after the end of the project, in line with the
UCL research data retention schedule. Anonymised data may also be used in follow-up research (subject to ethics approval).

What will happen to the results of the research?

We will write up our findings for publication in conference papers, journal articles, PhD theses, and reports to participating schools. On request, the research team is happy to make the results available to participants (contact the Principal Investigator listed above).

Does my child have to take part?

No. It is entirely up to you whether you allow your child to take part. If you provide consent, your child will also be asked to give their assent (agreement) to participate, ensuring they understand what is involved and are comfortable taking part. If your child is taking part through their school and wishes to participate but you have not provided consent, or if they do not wish to participate, they will still be

invited to join all learning activities like everyone else; however, their data will not be included in the research analysis.

Can I or my child withdraw from the study?

Yes. You or your child can change your mind and withdraw at any time during the study and up to two weeks after your child's final session, without giving a reason and without any negative consequences for your child's grades. To withdraw, please email the Principal Investigator with your child's name who will liaise with the researchers.

To enable withdrawal during this window, we keep a separate, secure linking file that maps your child's name/class/school (where applicable) to their pseudonymous study ID. The UCL coordinating team and the Designated Safeguarding Leads can access this file. After the two-week window, your child's entry in the linking file is deleted from that point it is difficult to identify and remove individual data. If your child withdraws within the window, we will delete the data collected about them; we keep a copy of your original consent form and withdrawal request under UCL retention policy. Your statutory rights are not affected.

You may also withdraw from the interview at any time, without giving a reason. In this case, your interview data will be deleted.

Safeguarding during the research

The application is intended for schoolwork, and we ask students not to enter personal information. However, the research team will store and read what your child types. The content will also be checked automatically for anything indicating that your child or someone else may be at risk of harm. If such content is identified, a dedicated safeguarding lead will review it, inform your child that it has been seen, and share it with the safeguarding lead at your child's school. If your child is not participating through a school, it may instead be shared with you or, where necessary, an appropriate external service so that suitable support can be provided. This is the only circumstance in which we cannot keep what your child writes confidential, and we will explain this to students before they begin.

The application is only available during agreed hours (6:00 to 22:00) and switched off overnight.

Data Protection Notice

UCL is the data controller for the personal data collected through this research. UCL will process personal data for the purpose of the research outlined above. Research is a task that we perform in the public interest. For more information, see the UCL General Research Participant Privacy Notice.

UCL General Research Participant Privacy Notice

If you are concerned about how personal data is being processed, or would like to contact us about your rights, please contact the UCL Data Protection Officer at **data-protection@ucl.ac.uk**.

Complaints

If you have any concerns or complaints about the conduct of this project, you are welcome to contact the UCL IOE Research Ethics Office:

Executive Officer

UCL IOE Research Ethics Office

UCL Institute of Education

University College London

20 Bedford Way

London WC1H 0AL

United Kingdom

Email: ioe.researchethics@ucl.ac.uk

Contact for further information

Professor Manolis Mavrikis

UCL Principal Investigator

Email: **m.mavrikis@ucl.ac.uk**

Tel: 02079074634

Thank you very much for taking the time to read this information sheet.